Interview Bank (all programmes)

Six true stories you prepare once and reuse everywhere, plus programme-specific questions

1. Your six core stories (STAR, 60–90 seconds each)

Write each story from real events only. Every interview below draws on these six.

#	Story	Situation	Task	Action (what *you* did)	Result (real only)	Use for
S1	A production incident you resolved	[⏳]	[⏳]	[⏳]	[⏳]	CMU, AISS, SMACCs, SI
S2	Something you automated	[⏳]	[⏳]	[⏳]	[⏳]	CMU, EDISS, CSC
S3	A time you led, coordinated or trained people	[⏳]	[⏳]	[⏳]	[⏳]	CMU (Mastercard Foundation), SI
S4	Working with external partners (banks, merchants)	[⏳]	[⏳]	[⏳]	[⏳]	SMACCs, AISS
S5	A failure or mistake and what you changed	[⏳]	[⏳]	[⏳]	[⏳]	All
S6	Giving back (Dereja, mentoring)	[⏳]	[⏳]	[⏳]	[⏳]	CMU, AISS, SI

2. Hard questions every panel may ask

Question	Honest answer outline
Your GPA is 2.62. Why should we choose you?	The trend (final year 3.20, own calculation); A− in Advanced Programming, Compiler Design, Complexity Theory and the final project; years of production responsibility; public code you wrote
Why a master’s now?	The design gap you hit in story S1
What will you do after?	A specific role and problem in Ethiopia’s digital-payments infrastructure
How will you fund the costs not covered?	Use the real figures from your financial plan
Do you have AI or research experience?	Introductory AI course (B); no research publications; production data experience. Say what you want to learn

Question	Honest answer outline
Why this country / programme?	Two concrete curriculum or path reasons (from each package)

3. Programme-specific question sets

- **CMU-Africa:** `07_CMU_AFRICA/CMU-Africa_SUBMISSION_PACK`, section 11.
  - Video essay cannot be re-recorded (section 5).
  - Technical test (section 7).
- **AISS:** `09_AISS/AISS_SUBMISSION_PACK`, section 7 (interview).
  - 10-minute presentation + 5 minutes of questions.
  - Do not read from the screen.
- **SMACCs:** `10_SMACCs/SMACCs_SUBMISSION_PACK`, section 8 (interviews 7–18 April 2027).
- **DUT / CSC:** possible call with a supervisor. Prepare:
  - 2 minutes on the study plan
  - 2 minutes on your work
  - 2 questions about their lab
- **Canadian research MSc:** professor call. Prepare:
  - the paper you read
  - your proposed question
  - what you can contribute in the first semester

4. Practice plan

When	Session
Week of 16 Nov	Write S1–S6 (I review them)
By 5 Dec	CMU video-essay practice: 5 recorded takes, 60–90 s each
By 10 Dec	Technical-test drills (CMU pack, section 7)
January	AISS 10-minute presentation: 3 recorded rehearsals
March–April	SMACCs and AISS mock interviews if you are shortlisted